Asking for and giving information (wh-questions)

Goal: To ask for information with the right wh-word and the correct word order, and to answer such questions with short, precise information.

The idea in two lines: A wh-question starts with a question word (what, where, when, who, why, how...) followed by an auxiliary and the subject: Wh + auxiliary + subject + verb? The answer gives exactly the information the wh-word asks for.

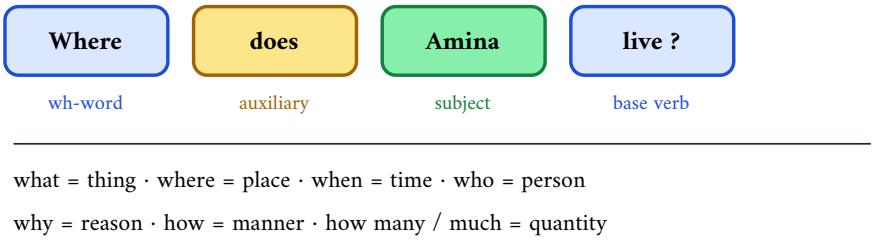


Figure 1: Word order of a wh-question and the information each question word asks for.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Word order:** Wh-word + auxiliary (do / does / is / are / can...) + subject + main verb. Example: When do you start school?
2. **With the verb "be"** there is no "do": Where are you from? What is your name?
3. **Who / What as subject:** no auxiliary is needed. Who teaches English? What happened?
4. **How + adjective / adverb:** How old, how far, how long, how often, how many (countable), how much (uncountable).
5. **Which** asks for a choice from a known set: Which bus goes to the centre?
6. **Whose** asks about possession: Whose bag is this?
7. **Answering:** give the information asked for, in a short or full sentence: Where do you live? – In Oran. / I live in Oran.

🟢 Examples

1. Ask about the underlined words: My sister studies medicine. **Answer:** What does your sister study? **Explanation:** "medicine" is a thing → what; the subject is third person → does; the main verb returns to its base form.
2. Ask about the underlined words: Karim won the race. **Answer:** Who won the race? **Explanation:** the question is about the subject, so no auxiliary is added and the verb keeps its past form.
3. The train leaves at 7 o'clock. **Answer:** When does the train leave? (or: What time does the train leave?)

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Forgetting the auxiliary: "Where you live?" instead of "Where do you live?"
- Keeping the -s or the past form after the auxiliary: "Where does she lives?" / "When did he went?"
- Confusing **how many** (books) with **how much** (money).
- Using "what" for a person: "What teaches you English?" instead of "Who teaches you English?"

🟡 Quick review

- Wh-word + auxiliary + subject + base verb?
- With "be": Wh-word + am / is / are + subject?
- Who / What as subject → no do / does / did.
- How many = countable, how much = uncountable.
- Find the kind of information (place, time, person, reason) and pick the matching wh-word.

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